

THE WAY

Foundational Theology Research Dossiers - Volume I

God / Revelation / Jesus / Muhammad / Buddha / Scripture / Human Condition

Evidence-separated research baselines; not final creed

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UNDECIDED

Research draft - not a closed canon or creed

Reading rule

Each dossier separates what sources say, what history can reasonably establish, what competing traditions infer, and what the Way may currently teach. An Open Question is a positive research status, not a defect.

How to read confidence

State	Use in these dossiers
Established	Strong evidence and broad responsible agreement for the defined claim; revision remains possible.
Well-Supported	Substantial evidence favors the claim, but meaningful uncertainty or dispute remains.
Provisional	Plausible working conclusion useful for practice or further inquiry, explicitly subject to revision.
Permitted Interpretation	A coherent interpretation Companions may hold, but the Assembly does not teach it as the best-established conclusion.
Open Question	Available evidence does not justify an Assembly conclusion.
Rejected as Harmful or Unsupported	Either evidentially untenable for the defined claim, or institutionally impermissible because the proposed use violates rights/safeguards. The reason must be stated.

TQ-001 - God / Ultimate Reality

Research question

What, if anything, is ultimately real in the religious sense, and what may responsibly be said about God or the Divine?

The evidence supports neither a premature equation of all religious ultimates nor a premature dismissal of them. Jewish and Islamic witnesses emphatically affirm divine unity; Sikh tradition likewise centers one God; Upanishadic traditions develop models of Brahman and self; Buddhist traditions are not organized around a creator God and instead analyze suffering, impermanence, non-self, dependent arising, and liberation. Philosophy of religion itself now treats 'God and other ultimates' as a plural conceptual landscape rather than one uniform idea.

Witness map

Witness	Source / corpus	Research use
Jewish biblical witness	Deuteronomy 6:4-5; Exodus 3:14-15	Unity/uniqueness of YHWH; covenantal love; divine naming remains interpretively rich.
Qur'anic witness	Qur'an 112; 4:171	God is one, incomparable, not begotten or begetting; Jesus is not a second deity within Qur'anic theology.
Sikh witness	Mool Mantar and Sikh teaching tradition	One, creator, timeless, self-existent divine reality; ego is an obstacle to truthful living.
Upanishadic witness	Principal Upanishadic traditions	Multiple formulations of Brahman, Atman, nonduality, and ultimate reality; not reducible to one simple doctrine.
Buddhist witness	Early Buddhist discourses	Liberation is framed without dependence on a creator-God doctrine; later Buddhist schools develop additional concepts such as emptiness and Buddha-nature.
Philosophical witness	Contemporary philosophy of religion	Distinguishes personal-God models, ground-of-being models, nondual ultimates, and non-theistic ultimates; also evaluates naturalism and skepticism.

Findings

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Religious traditions make materially different ultimate-reality claims.	Established	This diversity must not be erased by saying all traditions teach the same thing.
Monotheistic unity is central to Jewish, Islamic, and Sikh witnesses, though their further descriptions differ.	Established	Descriptive claim about source traditions, not an Assembly metaphysical verdict.

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Religious experience and testimony deserve study but do not uniquely determine one metaphysical interpretation.	Well-Supported	The same kind of human experience can be interpreted differently across traditions.
Whether ultimate reality is personal, transpersonal, nondual, plural, or adequately described by naturalism remains unsettled for the Way.	Open Question	No evidentiary shortcut is justified.
The problem of suffering and evil is a major test for any model of an all-powerful, all-knowing, perfectly good personal God.	Established	The force of the problem varies with the model of God being evaluated.

Major interpretations still in view

Classical monotheism: One personal creator God, maximally powerful/known/good; Jewish, Christian, Islamic and Sikh formulations vary.

Ground-of-being / panentheistic models: God as being itself, the ground within which creation exists, or reality transcending ordinary person-language.

Nondual models: Ultimate reality and deepest self/reality understood through forms of nonduality; important in several Hindu philosophical traditions.

Non-theistic liberation models: Religious ultimacy need not be a creator person; many Buddhist systems exemplify this.

Naturalism / agnosticism: No transcendent personal or metaphysical ultimate beyond nature, or insufficient evidence to decide.

Current Way posture

Status	Current posture
Established	The Way must distinguish different concepts of ultimacy rather than collapsing them into one.
Provisional	Devotional use of "God" is permitted as ordinary prayer language while metaphysical definition remains open.
Open Question	The Assembly does not yet adopt a binding doctrine of divine personality, Trinity, strict unitarianism, nonduality, panentheism, or naturalism.
Institutional safeguard	No claimant may convert a private certainty about God into unchecked authority over another person.

What would materially change confidence?

- Compelling publicly assessable evidence of divine action with reliable provenance and alternative explanations addressed.
- Philosophical arguments that substantially outperform rivals on coherence, explanatory power, and moral implications.

- Cross-tradition experiential evidence that discriminates among competing models rather than merely showing that religious experience occurs.
- New evidence bearing on consciousness, cosmology, mind, or religious experience relevant to the metaphysical models.

Next research questions

- How should divine attributes be evaluated?
- What is the relation between divine unity and personal plurality claims?
- Can prayer be epistemically informative without becoming self-validating?
- How should evil and apparently gratuitous suffering update confidence?

TQ-002 - Revelation / Prophecy

Research question

What counts as revelation, how can revelatory claims be evaluated, and what authority may such claims have?

Religions use 'revelation' for different things: alleged divine speech, divine acts in history, divine self-disclosure, inspired text, prophetic proclamation, awakened insight, or deepened perception of reality. A responsible system therefore evaluates revelation claims in layers rather than asking only whether a claimant is sincere.

Witness map

Witness	Source / corpus	Research use
Hebrew prophetic traditions	Torah and Prophets	Divine speech, covenant, vision, prophetic call, moral indictment, and historical interpretation.
Christian traditions	Jesus, apostolic witness, scripture, Spirit	Revelation may be centered in a person/event as well as words; later traditions disagree over continuing revelation.
Islamic tradition	Qur'an and prophetic mission	Qur'an is presented as revealed speech delivered through Muhammad; later hadith/sira are distinct source classes.
Buddhist traditions	Awakening / insight	The Buddha's authority is typically framed as awakening and insight rather than a creator deity dictating revelation.
Sikh tradition	Gurbani / Guru	Revelatory and devotional authority is mediated through the Gurus and Guru Granth Sahib in Sikh self-understanding.
Philosophy	Models of divine revelation	Revelation can mean alleged divine speaking, special acts, or broader divine self-disclosure; justification remains a separate question.

Findings

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Sincerity and intensity do not establish divine origin.	Established	They may establish that the person sincerely reports an experience.
A report of revelation and the interpretation of that report are distinct evidentiary objects.	Established	This is foundational to the Way's epistemic grammar.
Private revelation can rationally matter to the experiencer more than to outsiders.	Well-Supported	Public institutional claims require additional reasons accessible to those affected.

Claim	Confidence	Research note
History can study revelation claims and their effects but cannot by historical method alone prove a transcendent source.	Established	Metaphysical/theological inference requires additional argument.
No contemporary revelation claim should automatically amend doctrine or governance.	Established - Institutional	Rights and lawful amendment processes remain controlling.

Major interpretations still in view

Propositional revelation: God communicates truths in words or word-like content.

Historical-event revelation: Divine self-disclosure occurs through events interpreted within a community.

Personal revelation: A person is understood as the decisive self-disclosure of God, as in major Christian Christologies.

Illuminative / contemplative revelation: Insight arises through disciplined perception, contemplation, or awakening.

Natural revelation: Nature, reason, conscience, or the cosmos discloses divine reality apart from special prophecy.

Current Way posture

Status	Current posture
Established	Revelation claims are classified as claims before they are classified as authority.
Provisional	The Assembly may receive a personal testimony as spiritually meaningful without adopting its claimed divine interpretation.
Open Question	Whether any historical revelation is genuinely divine, and if so by what mechanism.
Institutional safeguard	No revelation can authorize sexual access, self-compensation, evidence destruction, coercion, rights suspension, or exemption from safeguarding.

What would materially change confidence?

- Reliable independent corroboration of otherwise inaccessible information under controlled conditions.
- Predictive or explanatory success that survives pre-registration, ambiguity controls, and alternative explanations where such testing is appropriate.
- Historical evidence materially improving the provenance of ancient revelation reports.
- A coherent theology explaining both successful and failed revelation claims without ad hoc immunization.

Next research questions

- Can revelation continue today?

- How should fulfilled and failed prophecy be scored?
- What role should moral character play without circular reasoning?
- What distinguishes inspiration, intuition, conscience, and revelation?

TQ-003 - Jesus / Christology

Research question

What can responsibly be said about Jesus historically, and which claims about his identity remain theological?

Jesus of Nazareth is among the best-attested founders or central figures of antiquity in the sense that multiple early Christian sources preserve traditions about him and external ancient sources attest the movement and his execution context. Historical method can establish a first-century Jewish teacher, a movement, and crucifixion under Pontius Pilate with high confidence. It cannot, by itself, prove incarnation, divine sonship in an ontological sense, miracle causation, or resurrection as a metaphysical event.

Witness map

Witness	Source / corpus	Research use
Pauline letters	Earliest extant Christian writings	Show an already existing movement centered on the crucified and risen Jesus; not biographies.
Synoptic Gospels	Mark, Matthew, Luke	Narrative/theological sources preserving earlier traditions; written decades after Jesus and requiring source criticism.
Gospel of John	Later canonical Gospel	Distinctive theological portrait; historically valuable but not interchangeable with Synoptic chronology or discourse.
Josephus / Tacitus and Roman context	External ancient witnesses	Support the existence of Jesus/Christians and Roman execution context; details and textual issues vary by source.
Qur'anic Jesus	Qur'an 4:171; 5:72-75 and related passages	Affirms Jesus as Messiah/messenger while rejecting identification with God and later Islamic interpretation disputes crucifixion.

Findings

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Jesus was a first-century Jewish figure associated with Galilee/Judaea who attracted followers.	Established	Mainstream historical conclusion.
Jesus was crucified under Pontius Pilate.	Established	Oxford scholarship describes this as nearly universally accepted / among the strongest historical points.
The Gospels are literary and theological texts as well as historical sources and must be read accordingly.	Established	Their theological aims neither erase nor automatically validate historical content.
Jesus preached about God/kingdom and ethical/religious transformation.	Well-Supported	Exact wording and scope of individual sayings vary in confidence.

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Jesus explicitly claimed ontological identity with God in the later creedal sense.	Open Question - Historical/Theological	The sources and interpretation are contested; historical method cannot simply assume later creeds.
Followers very early proclaimed that Jesus had been raised and continued to encounter him as alive.	Established as claim-history	What caused those experiences and whether resurrection occurred metaphysically remain separate questions.
Jesus' resurrection as a divine transformation of the dead.	Open Question - Metaphysical/Theological	Historical evidence can establish belief/claims more readily than supernatural causation.

Major interpretations still in view

Jewish prophetic / eschatological teacher: Jesus as Jewish teacher announcing God's reign and calling for repentance and transformed life.

Messianic claimant or messianically interpreted figure: Scholars debate how Jesus understood messiahship versus how followers came to interpret him.

Incarnate divine Son: Classical Christian doctrine; a theological claim that goes beyond what historical method alone can establish.

Islamic Messiah and messenger: Qur'anic and Islamic framework honors Jesus but rejects divine identity and commonly interprets crucifixion differently.

Nonreligious historical interpretations: Charismatic teacher, apocalyptic prophet, reformer, wisdom teacher, or combinations.

Current Way posture

Status	Current posture
Established	Jesus is a central witness in the Library of Witnesses and indispensable to study of the Way.
Established	His crucifixion under Pilate is taught as history.
Well-Supported	His teachings concerning God, neighbor, mercy, repentance, service, and moral transformation are major formation sources, with source-critical confidence noted passage by passage.
Open Question	Incarnation, Trinity, pre-existence, atonement mechanisms, miracle causation, empty-tomb details, and resurrection metaphysics are not yet Assembly doctrine.
Safeguard	Questioning a Christological interpretation is not grounds for retaliation or exclusion from ordinary public gatherings.

What would materially change confidence?

- Earlier independent sources materially changing the source map.
- New manuscript or archaeological evidence bearing directly on disputed sayings/events.
- Better historical models of post-crucifixion experiences that explain the rise of resurrection belief.

- Philosophical/theological arguments showing that one Christological model best integrates the historical and experiential evidence.

Next research questions

- Which sayings/actions have the highest historical confidence?
- How did Jesus understand sonship, messiahship, and authority?
- What best explains resurrection experiences and empty-tomb traditions?
- How should the Way relate Jesus' teaching to later Pauline and conciliar theology?

TQ-004 - Muhammad / Qur'anic Revelation

Research question

What can responsibly be said about Muhammad historically, and how should the Qur'an's revelation claim be evaluated?

Muhammad is historically secure as the seventh-century Arabian leader around whom the early Muslim community formed. The Qur'an is the earliest major source for his proclamation and is far closer to his lifetime than the developed sira and hadith corpora. The theological claim that the Qur'an is divine speech, and the traditional claim of final prophethood, require theological and philosophical assessment in addition to historical source criticism.

Witness map

Witness	Source / corpus	Research use
Qur'an	Earliest major Islamic source	Broad scholarly agreement, though not unanimity, treats its content as substantially deriving from Muhammad's proclamation; it is not arranged as a biography.
Early material evidence	Inscriptions, papyri, coins, early Qur'anic manuscripts	Important for dating, community identity, textual transmission, and early Islamic history.
Sira literature	Ibn Ishaq tradition preserved through later recensions and related biographies	Indispensable but later than the Qur'an and requires source criticism.
Hadith corpora	Later collections with isnad/matn traditions	Central to Islamic law and piety; historical evaluation is report-specific and methodologically complex.
Non-Muslim witnesses	Early Christian, Jewish, and other external notices	Potential independent data but often brief, polemical, or difficult to interpret.

Findings

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Muhammad was a seventh-century Arabian religious and political leader whose movement produced the early Muslim community.	Established	Basic historical conclusion.
The Qur'an is the earliest principal textual witness to Muhammad's proclamation.	Established	It remains incomplete as biography.
Later sira and hadith should not be given the same source weight as the Qur'an merely because tradition groups them together.	Established - Methodological	Each report requires provenance and transmission analysis.
The Qur'an presents Muhammad as messenger and "seal of the prophets."	Established - Textual	The meaning is central to Islamic theology; textual description is distinct from Assembly endorsement.

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Muhammad was divinely commissioned and the Qur'an is verbatim divine revelation.	Open Question - Theological	History can assess provenance and proclamation; divine origin requires additional inference.
Muhammad is necessarily the final possible bearer of revelation for all humanity.	Open Question for the Way	The Qur'anic claim and Islamic interpretation are studied seriously but not adopted automatically.

Major interpretations still in view

Classical Sunni/Shi'a prophethood: Muhammad as final prophet/messenger and Qur'an as divine revelation; traditions differ on succession and authority.

Historical-critical account: Muhammad as late antique Arabian religious leader whose proclamation must be studied in its Jewish, Christian, Arabian, political, and linguistic setting.

Revisionist historical models: Some scholarship has challenged aspects of traditional chronology or source reliability; proposals require case-by-case evidence.

Interreligious prophetic recognition: Some non-Muslim thinkers regard Muhammad as a genuine religious reformer or prophetic witness without accepting every Islamic dogmatic claim.

Current Way posture

Status	Current posture
Established	Muhammad and the Qur'an are major witnesses that must be studied directly rather than through polemic.
Established	Source classes must remain differentiated: Qur'an, early material evidence, sira, hadith, tafsir, and later doctrine.
Open Question	Divine authorship, inimitability as proof, finality of prophethood, and the normative authority of later hadith for the Way.
Safeguard	No offense or reverence norm may be used to suppress good-faith historical inquiry or to license denigration of Muslims.

What would materially change confidence?

- New early manuscript/epigraphic evidence bearing on textual history and chronology.
- Stronger source-critical models linking specific biographical reports to early independent strata.
- Arguments for divine revelation that distinguish divine authorship from literary power, historical influence, or sincere conviction.
- Evidence clarifying how earliest Muslims understood prophecy, authority, and Qur'anic collection.

Next research questions

- What can be reconstructed from the Qur'an alone?
- How early and stable is the Qur'anic consonantal text, and what do reading traditions imply?
- How should hadith be stratified for historical versus devotional use?
- What exactly does "seal of the prophets" establish textually and theologically?

TQ-005 - Buddha / Awakening / Non-Self

Research question

What can responsibly be said about the historical Buddha, early Buddhist teaching, awakening, and non-self?

Current scholarship places Gautama Buddha roughly around the fifth century BCE and treats the early discourses preserved in multiple textual lineages as the principal evidence for reconstructing early Buddhist thought. The core liberation project - suffering/dukkha, craving, cessation, path, impermanence, and non-self - is much more secure as an early doctrinal complex than many elaborate later biographies or later-school metaphysics.

Witness map

Witness	Source / corpus	Research use
Nikayas / Agamas	Early Buddhist discourse collections preserved in Pali and Chinese/Sanskrit-related lineages	Comparative parallels help distinguish early shared strata from school-specific development.
Vinaya traditions	Monastic disciplinary collections	Preserve institutional and narrative memories, with layers.
SN 56.11	Setting in Motion the Wheel of Dhamma	Four truths, middle way, eightfold path, liberation.
SN 22.59	Characteristic of Not-Self	Five aggregates analyzed as not fit to identify as permanent controlling self.
Later Buddhist traditions	Abhidharma, Mahayana, Vajrayana and regional schools	Philosophically rich developments that should not be projected wholesale onto earliest Buddhism.

Findings

Claim	Confidence	Research note
A historical teacher Gautama stands behind the Buddhist tradition.	Established	Exact dates remain debated; roughly fifth century BCE is common in current scholarship.
The early liberation project centers on dukkha/suffering, its causal conditions, cessation, and a disciplined path.	Established	Attested across early sources.
Non-self is central to early Buddhist analysis of persons.	Established	Interpretation of precisely what is denied remains philosophically debated.
Early Buddhism includes karma/rebirth language as part of its inherited and transformed framework.	Established - Textual	Whether rebirth is metaphysically true remains open for the Way.
The Buddha achieved a literally final liberation ending rebirth.	Open Question - Metaphysical	The historical fact of a liberation claim is distinct from metaphysical verification.

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Later concepts such as Madhyamaka emptiness or Buddha-nature can simply be attributed to the historical Buddha.	Rejected as historically careless	Later developments require their own provenance.

Major interpretations still in view

Theravada early-text reading: Emphasizes Nikaya/Vinaya traditions and liberation through ethics, meditation, and wisdom.

Mahayana developments: Reframe emptiness, bodhisattva ideals, Buddha bodies, and other doctrines through later corpora.

Secular/psychological appropriations: Extract meditation and suffering analysis while bracketing karma/rebirth; useful but not identical with traditional Buddhism.

Comparative theological reading: Treats Buddhist insight as a witness about attachment, selfhood, suffering, and contemplative knowledge without forcing it into a creator-God framework.

Current Way posture

Status	Current posture
Established	The Buddha is a major witness to disciplined inquiry into suffering, desire, attention, selfhood, and liberation.
Well-Supported	Practices of ethical restraint, attention, meditation, and examination of craving deserve experimental and comparative study.
Open Question	Rebirth, karma across lives, nirvana's metaphysical nature, and whether non-self is ultimately compatible with soul or resurrection models.
Safeguard	Buddhist testimony is studied in its own categories before any synthesis with Abrahamic theology.

What would materially change confidence?

- Earlier textual parallels or manuscript discoveries that materially change the reconstruction of early strata.
- Better philosophical accounts of personal identity, consciousness, and continuity that engage Buddhist arguments directly.
- Empirical evidence relevant to contemplative claims, while avoiding the mistake that therapeutic effects prove all Buddhist metaphysics.

Next research questions

- What exactly does anatta deny?
- How should dependent arising be interpreted across early strata?
- Which meditation claims are phenomenologically reproducible?
- How should karma/rebirth claims be evaluated without dismissing or presupposing them?

TQ-006 - Scripture / Canon / Authority

Research question

What makes a text scripture, how do canons form, and should the Way have a canon?

The comparative record shows that scripture and canon are historically mediated categories. Jewish authoritative literature developed over time and Second Temple evidence shows graded authority; the New Testament canon formed gradually with core collections and later disputed books; Qur'anic collection and reading traditions have their own early history; Buddhist traditions preserve multiple canons in different languages; Sikh tradition offers a different model in which the Guru Granth Sahib itself holds living scriptural/Guru authority. These mechanisms cannot be collapsed into one theory of inspiration.

Witness map

Witness	Source / corpus	Research use
Jewish textual history	Torah, Prophets, Writings; Dead Sea Scrolls	Shows authority, interpretation, and eventual canonization as historically layered.
Christian textual history	Gospels, Pauline letters, catholic epistles, Acts, Revelation, extracanonical literature	Core texts circulated early while disputed boundaries stabilized over centuries.
Qur'anic textual history	Recitation, collection, consonantal text, canonical readings	Distinct model centered on a single revealed corpus with oral/written transmission and recognized readings.
Buddhist canons	Pali, Sanskrit fragments, Chinese and Tibetan collections	Plural canonical lineages; early-text reconstruction often compares parallels across schools/languages.
Sikh scripture	Guru Granth Sahib	Distinctive model of scripture bearing continuing Guru authority within Sikh tradition and containing compositions from multiple voices.

Findings

Claim	Confidence	Research note
A text calling itself sacred does not by itself establish its own canon status.	Established	Canon is also a community/institutional reception category.
Jewish and Christian canon formation was historically gradual rather than a single universally recognized list from the beginning.	Established	Specific dates/boundaries require tradition-sensitive nuance.
Second Temple Jewish evidence can reflect graded levels of authoritative literature.	Well-Supported	Qumran research is particularly important.

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Multiple Buddhist canons and parallel early texts complicate any claim that one bounded book-list uniquely represents the historical Buddha.	Established	Comparative textual work is essential.
The Way presently needs a closed canon.	Rejected - Premature	Closing the source field now would outrun the research and create avoidable authority risks.

Major interpretations still in view

Inspired bounded canon: A divinely intended set of books eventually recognized by the faithful community.

Community-reception model: Texts become normative through long use, perceived apostolic/prophetic connection, coherence, liturgy, and communal reception.

Scripture-with-living-interpretation: Textual authority functions inseparably from interpretive community/tradition.

Open library / graded authority: Sources can have different research, formative, liturgical, and doctrinal weights without a single binary canon line.

Current Way posture

Status	Current posture
Established	The Assembly will maintain a Library of Witnesses rather than declare an early canon.
Established	Library inclusion means relevance for study, not inspiration or doctrinal endorsement.
Provisional	Sources may receive separate research, formation, liturgical, and doctrinal statuses.
Reserved	Any future canon requires a separate entrenched adoption process and should not occur merely for branding or imitation.

What would materially change confidence?

- Long-term evidence that a stable bounded corpus is necessary for faithful transmission and can be adopted without suppressing relevant counter-witnesses.
- A mature theology of revelation and inspiration capable of explaining why specific texts have a qualitatively different status.
- Multigenerational reception showing durable communal discernment rather than founder-era preference.

Next research questions

- What levels of authority should the Library support?
- Can liturgical reading be authorized without doctrinal authority?
- How should translations, manuscript variants, and critical editions be governed?

- What would justify any future canon closure?

TQ-007 - Human Condition / Soul / Consciousness

Research question

What is the human problem, what is a person, and what forms of transformation are warranted before the Way settles soul/afterlife metaphysics?

Across traditions, striking but incomplete convergence appears at the practical level: human beings are finite, vulnerable to suffering, prone to self-deception and harmful desire, shaped by habits and communities, capable of cruelty and compassion, and capable of significant transformation through disciplined practice and relationship. The metaphysical explanations remain deeply different: image-of-God anthropology, sin and grace, fitrah and moral accountability, Buddhist non-self and craving, Sikh haumai/ego, and Hindu models of self, karma, and ignorance are not interchangeable.

Witness map

Witness	Source / corpus	Research use
Genesis 1:27 and Jewish traditions	Humanity in the image of God	Supports dignity/vocation interpretations; later Jewish anthropology is diverse.
Jesus traditions	e.g., Mark 7:20-23 and related ethical teaching	Locates moral corruption in dispositions/actions arising from within, not merely ritual contamination.
Pauline / Christian traditions	Sin, flesh/spirit, grace, new creation	Highly influential Christian anthropology; multiple later theories of original sin and salvation.
Qur'an 30:30; 91:7-10	Fitrah, moral discernment, purification/corruption	Human created disposition and accountability; Islamic anthropology is broader than these verses alone.
Early Buddhist texts	dukkha, craving, impermanence, non-self	Frames the problem without a permanent controlling self and emphasizes liberation through insight/practice.
Sikh teaching	haumai / ego and truthful living	Ego-centeredness is a key obstacle; remembrance and truthful living are central remedies.

Findings

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Humans are vulnerable to cognitive bias, self-deception, social influence, harmful desire, and moral failure.	Established	Supported by ordinary experience and multiple religious/psychological traditions; exact mechanisms vary.
Humans are also capable of compassion, learning, conscience, repair, self-regulation, and transformation.	Established	A one-sided doctrine of depravity is not warranted by the comparative evidence alone.
Human dignity should not depend on religious status, purity, caste, office, wealth, sex, or loyalty to the institution.	Established - Ethical/Institutional	Constitutional commitment of the Way.

Claim	Confidence	Research note
Humans possess an immaterial immortal soul of a specific type.	Open Question - Metaphysical	Traditions and philosophical theories conflict.
No enduring self exists in any meaningful sense.	Open Question - Metaphysical	Early Buddhist non-self analysis is a major challenge to substantial-self theories but requires careful philosophical engagement.
Inherited guilt/original sin is the correct universal diagnosis.	Open Question	Distinguish inherited conditions, social transmission, biological propensity, and culpability.

Major interpretations still in view

Image of God / covenantal personhood: Human worth and vocation grounded in relation to God.

Sin/grace anthropology: Humanity impaired by sin and dependent on divine grace; many Christian variants.

Fitrah/accountability: Humans created with a primordial disposition toward truth/God yet capable of corruption and repentance.

Non-self / craving / ignorance: Suffering maintained by craving, misperception, and attachment to self; liberation through ethical and contemplative insight.

Ego/haumai: Self-centeredness obscures truthful relation to God and others; remembrance/service reorient the person.

Naturalistic psychology: Human cognition and morality explained through biological, developmental, psychological, and social processes without metaphysical soul assumptions.

Current Way posture

Status	Current posture
Established	All leaders and Companions are treated as fallible; governance must assume susceptibility to bias, temptation, dependency, and self-justification.
Established	Every person retains dignity and conscience regardless of religious status.
Provisional	Formation should cultivate attention, honesty, compassion, restraint, service, repair, and intellectual humility because these respond to human vulnerabilities across models.
Open Question	Soul, consciousness after death, rebirth, resurrection, inherited sin, and ultimate mechanism of transformation.

What would materially change confidence?

- Advances in philosophy/neuroscience of consciousness that strongly favor or undermine specific models of personal identity.
- Credible evidence bearing on survival of consciousness, rebirth, resurrection, or other postmortem claims.

- Better exegesis/source criticism clarifying what the earliest witnesses actually taught about personhood and moral failure.
- Longitudinal evidence on which formation practices produce durable prosocial transformation without coercive harms.

Next research questions

- What is consciousness?
- What constitutes personal identity over time?
- How should sin, ignorance, craving, ego, trauma, habit, and social structure relate?
- What exactly can be taught to children without imposing unresolved metaphysics?

Comparative synthesis

The seven dossiers do not yield the conclusion that all religions are the same. They yield a narrower and more defensible result: major traditions preserve different witness systems addressing overlapping human questions, and those systems sometimes converge ethically or phenomenologically while remaining metaphysically incompatible.

The Way can therefore inherit practices of disciplined attention, prayer, moral transformation, study, service, and companionship before it settles every metaphysical question. Practice must remain revisable where it rests on provisional theories.

The founder is not a source class above the Library. Contemporary founder statements enter the record as testimony, argument, policy proposal, or teaching proposal and are evaluated through the same method.

Research-source notes

S1 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Philosophy of Religion". Alternative concepts of God/ultimate reality; religious and naturalistic worldviews. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/philosophy-religion/>

S2 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "God and Other Ultimates". Plural models of ultimacy: God, Brahman, Dao, emptiness, and others. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/god-ultimates/>

S3 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Divine Revelation". Models of revelation and epistemic justification. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/divine-revelation/>

S4 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "Religious Diversity (Pluralism)". Exclusivist, inclusivist, pluralist responses; incompatible claims. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/religious-pluralism/>

S5 - Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy, "The Problem of Evil". Different concepts of God and evidential/logical problem of evil. <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/evil/>

S6 - Sefaria, Deuteronomy 6:4-5 / Shema. Jewish biblical witness to divine unity and love of God. <https://www.sefaria.org/Deuteronomy.6.4>

S7 - Sefaria, Genesis 1:27. Image-of-God anthropology. <https://www.sefaria.org/Genesis.1.27>

S8 - Quran.com, Surah al-Ikhlās 112. Qur'anic divine unity/incomparability. <https://quran.com/al-ikhlas>

S9 - Quran.com, Qur'an 30:30. Fitrah language. <https://quran.com/30/30>

S10 - Quran.com, Qur'an 91:7-10. Soul, moral discernment, purification/corruption. <https://quran.com/91/7-10>

S11 - Quran.com, Qur'an 33:40. Muhammad as messenger and seal of prophets in Qur'anic text. <https://quran.com/33/40>

S12 - Oxford Academic, F. E. Peters, "Muhammad" (Oxford Bibliographies). Qur'an as principal early biographical source; broad scholarly judgment about proclamation. <https://academic.oup.com/reference/62361/reference-article-abstract/554568841>

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